CREATIVE METAPHOR TASK

This task was first presented in these papers:

> Beaty, R. E., & Silvia, P. J. (2013). Metaphorically speaking: Cognitive abilities and the production of figurative language. *Memory and Cognition*, *41*, 255-267.
>
> Silvia, P. J., & Beaty, R. E. (2012). Making creative metaphors: The importance of fluid intelligence for creative thought. *Intelligence, 40*, 343-351.

Note. People are given as much time as they like for each item, but it is worth measuring their response time. They are asked to come up with only one response. We have MediaLab randomize the order of the items, but this probably isn't essential. As with most cognitive lab tasks, it would be worth exploring variations in task parameters, response options, and instructions.

The actual prompts are flexible and can be replaced to suit your population. Ideally, the prompt should be emotional evocative, which makes it easier to come up with something creative. It is important that the participants understand that they should come up with a creative metaphor, not just any old metaphor.

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MAKING METAPHORS

For this task, you'll be asked to come up with creative metaphors to describe things. As a background, there are a few common kinds of metaphors, and you can come up with any kind of them for this task.

A *simple metaphor* describes something by equating it to something else. Examples of simple metaphors are "All the world is a stage" (Shakespeare) and "A committee is a cul-de-sac down which ideas are lured and then quietly strangled" (Sir Barnett Cocks).

A *simile* (which is a kind of metaphor) describes something by saying it is like something else. An example of a simile is "Justice is like a train that is nearly always late" (Yevgeny Yevtushenko).

A *compound metaphor* has a second part that extends and explains the metaphor. Examples are "Life is like a box of chocolates: you never know what you're going to get" (from the film "Forest Gump") and "Men are like a fine wine: they all start out like grapes, and it's our job to stomp on them and keep them in the dark until they mature into something you'd like to have dinner with" (Kathleen Mifsud).

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You'll be asked to come up with two metaphors. They can be any kind (a metaphor, a simile, or a compound metaphor). The aim is to come up with something creative---something clever, humorous, original, compelling, or interesting.

You'll have as much time as you like; just press enter when you're done writing the metaphor.

Please click on "Continue" to start the metaphor task.

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Think of the most boring high-school or college class that you've ever had: What was it like to sit through?

Please describe the experience with a metaphor. (If you need a start, you can try a beginning like "That class was...", "Being in that class was like...", or "Sitting through that class was like...")

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Think about the most disgusting thing you ever ate or drank. What was it like to eat or drink it?

Please describe the experience with a metaphor.